

Chapter 103 - Returning Home

"A merperson?" Jiuying raised her eyebrows to look up at the figure in mid-air again, examining with interest. "It's said that the merperson clan has long lived at the bottom of the sea and never shows themselves to the world. This is also my first time seeing one."

"The Penglai Right Envoy is actually a merperson. Merpeople are naturally pure and clear by nature. How did he get involved with those scum from Penglai?" Jiuying's expression was quite melancholic.

Ning Fuyi said nothing more. She spread her arms and flew up, then her robes rustled as she descended.

Getting closer to the merperson, she could see him more clearly. Though his appearance wasn't particularly refined or stunning enough to amaze, when looking at him, his features appeared hazy, and after a while, one would feel somewhat entranced.

Ning Fuyi looked away and clapped her hands.

After a while, the merperson finally moved. His seaweed-like hair seemed to sway with the water, and his eyes slowly opened.

Those eyes were indescribable - three parts more colorful than precious pearls, seven parts less bright than stars, with soft mist covering them. When placed on his unremarkable face, they instantly made him appear divinely beautiful.

Those eyes fell upon Ning Fuyi's dark mask and silently opened: "Who are you?"

Ning Fuyi looked into his mouth and saw his tongue was still there, so his throat had been poisoned mute.

What a Penglai, what an Emperor Tianrui¹.

"I am the Hall Master of the Dread Hall². I heard that the Penglai Right Envoy was imprisoned here, so I came specially to pay my respects." Ning Fuyi spoke, her roughened voice echoing in the vast seabed.

Those eyes stared at her for a while, the corner of his mouth twisted in mockery, and he leaned back against his arms again, ignoring her.

Ning Fuyi had already anticipated this reaction and didn't mind. She continued speaking to herself: "The Penglai Right Envoy is upright by nature, resourceful, and Emperor Tianrui's most loyal subordinate. However, over two thousand years ago, he committed a crime and was cast into Yichan Sea by the Emperor..."

Those eyes opened again, looking at Ning Fuyi with undisturbed calm.

"Come closer." He mouthed the words.

Ning Fuyi stepped forward two paces, leaving only half an arm's distance between them.

"I have something to tell you." The merperson opened his mouth again, his eyes like deep sea depths, misty with white vapor.

Ning Fuyi seemed to see white sand stirred up by whirlpools on the seabed through the water. She remained silent for a moment, then leaned closer again.

When her earlobe felt the merperson's breath, she calmly raised her hand, turning her head to avoid his suddenly opened mouth full of silver teeth, letting him bite her wrist instead.

Bright red blood flowed down the corner of his mouth. The merperson's emotions stirred slightly as he looked at the slender wrist he had bitten, slowly opening his mouth.

Ning Fuyi withdrew her hand, shaking off the dripping blood as if shaking off water, and stepped back to stand properly.

"Can you listen to me now?" Ning Fuyi smiled lightly.

The merperson lowered his head, his blood-stained lips glistening red, his hazy face gaining some vitality: "Dread Hall - I've never heard of it."

"You shouldn't have heard of it. After all, in this seabed tens of thousands of li³ deep, you probably can't hear about such trivial matters." Ning Fuyi lowered her head to bandage her wound. "You only need to know that I am the Hall Master of Dread Hall, and I hate Penglai."

"Why?"

"They publicized deeds I never committed, harmed my friends for crimes I never committed, forcing me to hide in darkness, having to conceal my identity and live in disgrace. Don't you think that deserves hatred?"

The merperson said nothing but moved his fingertips.

"What about you? What kind of heinous crime was it that warranted imprisoning you at the bottom of the sea for two thousand years, and even..." Ning Fuyi looked at the merperson's throat, causing his bare shoulders to hunch for a moment.

"But you're hiding your appearance so secretively - how can I trust you?" The merperson raised his eyes.

"You misunderstand. I didn't come to make you trust me, but to save you." Ning Fuyi remained unmoved and didn't remove her mask. "I do need your help, but in the current situation, I think you need me more."

"If you agree to help me, I'll help you. If you don't agree, then pretend I never came here. You and I will remain strangers who met by chance."

The merperson's pale eyelashes trembled: "What do you mean?"

"You've been forgotten here for two thousand years. Haven't you noticed that the guards have been increasing lately? Because Penglai without you is like missing half an arm - they want you to continue serving them." Ning Fuyi explained methodically.

She turned her back to the merperson, facing the enclosed seabed and the oppressive cliff wall before them.

"You might still harbor hope, thinking Penglai might spare you and let you return to the immortal platform. But those old foxes are extremely cautious. Having imprisoned you for two thousand years, how could they release a tiger back to the mountain?"

"So they've already prepared how to make you their complete puppet - a sure win with no loss."

These words made the merperson clench his fists. He opened his mouth several times but couldn't make a sound, the blood color on his lips becoming more vivid.

Only after finishing did Ning Fuyi turn back, her sleeves slowly swaying like dark butterfly wings.

Only then did the merperson stop the changing storms in his eyes, hatred flickering in them: "How can you help me?"

"I can plant spies here, and I can do the same in Penglai. But that old fox is extremely cautious - spies can't get close to him. That's why I thought of you."

"He won't trust anyone with brains, but he won't distrust a puppet whose memory he's altered and created with his own hands." Ning Fuyi took out a crystal-clear glass bottle.

"Give me your memories, and I guarantee you won't become a puppet. How about it?"

Seabed light flowed through the mask's gaps, illuminating her transparent eyes.

"You want me to be a spy?" The merperson's mouth corner lifted slightly, his lip movements slowing. "But I never lie."

Ning Fuyi shook her head, her gaze regretful: "Never lie? But you can no longer speak."

The merperson was stunned, his face flushing, and he didn't speak again for a long while.

"Jiuying, come up." Ning Fuyi said in her mind. Then fragrant wind arose as a charming woman landed beside her, arms crossed, sizing up the bound merperson before them.

"This is my first time seeing a merperson. When they reach the age to develop gender, do they grow it overnight, or..."

The merperson looked coldly at Jiuying, who smiled back at him.

"I'll give you the memories."

The merperson spoke, wiggling his toes: "But before that, could you help me with something?"

Seeing that he had finally relented, Ning Fuyi's heartstrings relaxed considerably, her tone becoming gentler: "Speak."

The merperson lowered his eyes: "I've been standing for two thousand years and am somewhat tired. I'd like to rest."

Rest? Ning Fuyi looked at his reddened toes, then at the water chains covered in frost that pierced through his body. Without saying much, she raised her hand, pink immortal light flowing from her palm like several long silk ribbons entwining with the water.

Then she gave a low shout, forcefully pulling her hands down. The sound of surging sea arose on all sides, like wailing ghosts crying. At the same time, the water chains were pulled from the seabed and slowly descended.

Finally freed from the seawater's suspension, the merperson's body immediately fell. Ning Fuyi gestured for Jiuying to support him, but Jiuying looked up and pretended not to see.

Ning Fuyi had to step forward herself, supporting his waist through her sleeves. She saw phosphorescent light blazing as those slender legs somehow merged together, transforming into a brilliant fish tail.

The end was thin as cicada wings, seeming to sway with the water current. Ning Fuyi was somewhat entranced by this beautiful tail, but quickly collected her thoughts and gently placed him on the ground.

The merperson lay flat, feeling the fish tail he hadn't manifested in a thousand years, looking at the floating sunlight in Yichan Sea above. In his daze, several pearls fell with a pattering sound.

"Take them." He opened his mouth. "Memories."

"Don't deceive me. I can't endure it anymore."

Seeing this, Ning Fuyi felt somewhat moved. She waved her hand to collect the pearls in a bottle, carefully storing them away. Then she waved her hand to remove her mask, revealing her pure white jade countenance.

"Ning Fuyi." She smiled.

The merperson stared at her appearance in a daze, his fish tail curling.

"Yun Ke⁴."

After emerging from Yichan Sea again, Ning Fuyi was shivering all over from the cold. After escaping the seaside sandstorm, she sat on a reef in a few steps, shivering as she thawed herself.

Jiuying walked over with a normal expression, helping her brush off the ice crystals on her body, saying in surprise: "This seawater is just cold for me, but how is it like ice when it touches you? Very different?"

Ning Fuyi's lips turned blue as she wrung out the water from her skirt hem, letting it evaporate into white vapor.

"Yichan Sea imprisons fallen immortals and demons. You're a divine beast, so naturally you're not afraid." Ning Fuyi generated a ball of fire under her feet.

"Aren't you also a demon?" As soon as Jiuying finished speaking, her eyes widened. She immediately didn't care about elegance and crouched down in front of her. "Or is it that the demon tree in your body is again..."

Ning Fuyi didn't refute, reaching out to warm herself by the fire: "Alright, quickly help me ask how Su Mo is doing."

"Oh." Jiuying reached out to create a piece of blue feather, wrote a few words on it, then put it away.

"Hannya says she's doing well, still busy making nourishing pills for you." Jiuying teasingly poked Ning Fuyi's head. "Really nauseating."

Ning Fuyi smiled with dimples showing. Her clothes happened to be dry, so she got up to return, flying several li in the blink of an eye.

Jiuying hurriedly stood up, traveling on light: "Wait, why did you stop talking halfway? That's demonic energy - don't mess around!"

Yichan Sea was really far from the town. Despite their extremely fast pace, the round trip still took more than three days. Fortunately, Ning Fuyi had maintained close contact with Hannya and knew Su Mo was fine.

With Su Mo in her life, Ning Fuyi experienced for the first time what it meant to be eager to return home⁵. She couldn't spare any attention for the mountains and rivers beneath her feet.

Finally, at dusk the next day, she saw the rouge box-like town and landed with the setting sun's rosy clouds, running wildly with her skirt flying behind her. The evening breeze felt refreshing.

She pushed open the door forcefully, but the room was dark and empty. Just as her heart tightened, the bird crouching under the window catching insects suddenly started chattering: "Riverside, riverside, riverside..."

Ning Fuyi turned and jumped out of the threshold, her voice scattering into the warm wind: "Thank you!"

"Scoundrel, scoundrel, scoundrel..." The bird fluttered again.

Ning Fuyi left the bird calls and insect chirping behind her, letting her disheveled hair sweep across her cheeks. From far away, she could see a back sitting blankly on the wooden bridge.

Unable to shout, she picked up a stone from the ground and threw it far into the water in front of Su Mo.

The splashing water startled her. Su Mo got up in panic, but when she turned and discovered it was the woman, joy immediately spread across her face.

Ning Fuyi also smiled. She stepped forward and opened her arms, watching the rosy clouds stretch for thousands of li, the mountains all one color, watching Su Mo in her brilliant blue dress running toward her.

Watching Su Mo's radiant smile suddenly raise her hand, covering her heart and stopping in a daze.

"Su Mo..." Ning Fuyi stared in shock, watching fresh blood pour from Su Mo's mouth, dripping down from the wooden bridge into the orange-red river water.

Footnotes:

1. **Emperor Tianrui (天瑞帝君)** - The ruler of Penglai, representing the corrupt leadership that has imprisoned and tortured the merperson.
2. **Dread Hall (懔畏堂)** - Ning Fuyi's demon organization, literally meaning "Hall of Fear and Dread."
3. **Li (里)** - A traditional Chinese unit of distance, approximately 500 meters or about one-third of a mile.
4. **Yun Ke (云客)** - The merperson's name, literally meaning "Cloud Guest," revealing his identity for future plot development.
5. **Eager to return home (归心似箭)** - A Chinese idiom literally meaning "heart like an arrow returning home," expressing intense longing to return to one's beloved.